7

Clearing the last bite from his fork, he suppressed a grunt of pleasure. Shug was right, he admitted as he slowly chewed…best damn glazed kell he'd ever had. They'd put a little whiskey and jam of shuura in the sauce that helped mellow the gameyness of the meat. Even the vegetable sides had been roasted to perfection–a slight char that rounded out the meal with that hint of smoke. Surveying his space–yes, he'd finished it and no morsel remained–he rested his utensils crisscross on his plate. The bartender, attentive as she'd been all night, quickly swapped out his plate for the check. He acknowledged her with a slight tilt, then sat back, full, sated, and lazily reached for his glass of well-paired Corellian whiskey.

For a little while, he sat there contentedly, half listening to the low chatter and noise of the restaurant while his other half remained suspended in a calm, relishing the lingering flavor of the meal while the alcohol washed over and through him. When his comm chirped, he only leaned forward, slow, in no hurry to read the message: confirmation of the deposit. He nodded, pleased. The transaction settled, he could make his way back to the 'Suub…when he was ready; his whiskey was too good to throw back like swill.

Once he finally finished his drink, he perused again the check, then methodically reached into his jacket for the necessary coin. The bartender had been good to him, and he paid slightly over, then came to his feet and made sure he stood steadily enough. He smiled–he'd barely drunk enough to have much of an effect on him save some euphoria; hardly enough to incapacitate him. He gave a clipped wave to the busy bartender then meandered out of the restaurant.

The very beginnings of dawn met him as he stepped out onto the avenue, a faint tan glow that, high above, thinned into wispy silver strands of cloud. Despite the hour, this sector of Ashara still bustled, albeit slower than it had when he'd entered a couple hours prior, due to its proximity to the nearby port. He had a reasonable hike to get back to his docking bay, but as he crossed the avenue, he caught sight

of the headlights of an oncoming bus, its marquee displaying its destination as the port, and he jogged a little to just catch the bus as it made it to the nearby stop. The solitary rider, he picked a seat across from the back exit, then sprawled slightly, enjoying the stretch and the fullness of his belly.

The bus ambled, taking its time and letting what traffic it encountered have right of way. In no rush, Han studied the surrounding city with mild interest, observing again the elongated hexagonal layout, repeated block after block. The Neldians boasted it was rooted in efficiency, but he wasn't sure of efficiency for what. Certainly not land-based travel, he mused, as the bus made another turn down another street at another wide angle. Humored, he regarded the bus driver, wondered if the constant zig-zagging ever made them dizzy, then also reasoned plenty of people might say the same thing about flying. He relaxed back in his seat, watching out at the horizon as the bus crested a hill that let him peer down onto the port and one of the industrial sectors. It, too, was mapped out into the blocky pattern that looked like…like…a sabacc card.

The city fell away from him. Sabacc…he hadn't played in a while. Nar Shaddaa's casinos were too rough for his taste, and he tried not to stay planetside on a trip longer than necessary. He wondered for a beat if he was out of practice, then decided then and there that he'd pull out his deck on the trip and play a few rounds of Solitary. He didn't have a randomizer the way the casinos would, but random draw could simulate the effects of a sudden card switch enough to flex his skills.

The thought jogged a memory, of playing with a few members of his squad while off duty, the way he had been holding such a shit hand–a Endurance card valued at negative eight and a three of Coins with a Null card in the static field to keep it from randomizing. It was a long shot, one that was probably a stupid gamble, especially as he'd talked a pretty big game prior to playing about his skills. To lose in front of his subordinates would have meant he'd have to get mean with them after play was over, and he'd never actually delighted in

being a dick the way the other officers seemed to. And then, the cards changed; the Endurance dissipated as a two of Staves manifested. He'd stared in disbelief a little too hard, his sabacc face slipping, before he hurriedly called the hand. The others couldn't believe it as he'd laid out his cards–the Null, the two, the three–for an Idiot's Array. It won him the main pot, the sabacc pot, and the muted grumbling of his subordinates for the next few weeks. Little did they release how much that stupid hand had spared them.

Maybe…maybe, just for the hell of it, he'd take his time for the next trip, someplace farther out on the Rim. Leisure had not been something he'd allowed himself much of, not just in the last half year, but probably since coming to Nar Shaddaa. Perhaps he'd finally come due to take a breather, in a way. Have some fun. Relax, if he could remember what that meant.

The slight jolt to the bus as it came to an abrupt stop brought him back to the present. A pedestrian–an offworlder, Han guessed, as he saw the too bright robes for a place like grungy Ashara–scampered across the street. He took stock of his surroundings, recognized he was a stop away from the first of multiple port drop-offs, and climbed to his feet. The vehicle rocked him gently for another kilometer–or kilobean, or whatever they called their little unit of measurement here–and he stepped off at Port Entrance Five.

Seven months had passed like this–job after job, each of them relatively easy. Rewarding, even, and very much to his pleasant surprise. He'd braced himself, upon returning from Esseles, for the Imperial stigma to lace his every interaction and cost him. He certainly babysat the newsfeeds and the Esselian police reports and paid a connection of his to alert him to any possible warrants or bounties. Smugglers like to make money however, and any of them might jump at the chance to snitch at his whereabouts, and he needed a finger in the wind. But it had never come to anything. He didn't think too much about why, because the why didn't matter. Only that he'd gotten lucky enough to shirk any responsibility for the riot. Or 'uprising,' as the Imperials like to call it; a lurking, mass conspiracy

was the only way for them to cover their asses about how brash and incompetent some of their own could be.

And so, his face clear, Han had been able to use his higher standing with the Hutts to start picking jobs on some of the more Imperial-adjacent worlds. In and of itself, that meant higher pay, and the Hutts followed through on their promise to up his percentage, so each job brought in more besides. He'd been able to use that money to get ahead instead of playing catch up all the time, to not have to make last minute fixes and instead anticipate the changes and improvements his ship required. Shug had certainly been pretty gleeful about that; Han had definitely made it worth the mechanic's while to stick his neck out for him. It meant that lately, work felt like work, not a string of fires he was always half a step behind.

His success hadn't really changed his standing amongst the other pilots. He'd not garnered too much attention, favorable or not, right when he first arrived on the Smuggler's Moon. Now, he had an uncomfortable awareness of them noticing him. They stared, avoided him when they crossed his path at the Spacebarn. He sat alone when he went to the bar, and no one offered to spot him while he worked out. Some had the gall to sneer at him or deny him service. But they did move out of his way. They may have muttered to themselves or bitched about him behind his back, but nobody yet had said anything to his face. They minded their business and their mouths. He could live with that; he hadn't come to Hutt Space to be liked, least not by them. And he did wonder, in a way that made a smirk crawl up his face: how much of all their bluster was simply because of a Blue Stain on his hands, and how much of it was jealousy? Success could be a funny thing.

To be fair, not everyone had balked. Salla, because she'd known about where he'd come from since the beginning and relished the story of his discharge, and Mako, because he wore the same stain. Rho…Han wasn't sure what to make of Rho. He'd hung back as the rumors had stirred. Hadn't come to him, hadn't said anything, never confronted him. They'd managed to just drift past each other. Han

stopped going to Veno's. Hadn't seen Lwyll at all. He wondered sometimes, how much it meant–the silence. And then he'd pick up another job and put off ruminating on it until the next time.

He argued with himself, each time the anxiety came up, that it didn't really matter–the only favor he needed was the Hutts. Theirs meant everything, and he continued to stand taller in their eyes. He could admit he was basking in it. More and more, he could have his pick of whatever or wherever the Hutts needed delivery. Well, sort of, he winced to admit. One destination, one trip, he had not attempted yet–at least not in his ship–and he had debated for a while now whether he was going to bother.

The question fell away for him as the door to his docking bay slid aside and revealed its contents: a rounded, red vessel that looked rather refined in the low lights of the bay, especially after her recent chemical rinse. That was how she had appeared when he'd first seen her, sitting quietly amongst the jumbled array of Ploy's used ship lot, her matte maroon hull almost glowing in a sliver of sunlight. She had easily been the best ship on the lot, and his eagerness to have his own vessel instead of constantly having to use those from the Hutt's mishmashed fleet had caused him to discount all her red flags during his inspection. He'd taken her up for a test flight and she'd been cooperative, maybe even a little spunky. He'd gauged she was due a few jobs here and there, so he'd haggled what he could off the sale price and paid in full the rest. The truth had come out within days of possessing her. Still, he yielded, his heart pulling a bit to see her grounded like this, all cleaned up…she wasn't so bad. He'd lost count of the money he'd spent on her thus far, but finally, it *showed*, in her appearance as much as her performance. Hell, sometimes he swore the ship sat up straighter on her landing gear. She still had her quirks, and sure, things still cropped up–they always would, that was inevitable–but now when they happened, he was ready.

He strolled the distance to the keypad, enjoying his warmth for her, then also felt it fall away as the gangplank lowered. His chest braced at whatever–if anything–might await him inside. Esseles had

brought a change in fortune, but it had been at the cost of his copilot's patience. Chewie still hadn't gotten over the whole *woikeis* thing– ironic, as Han learned afterward, that the word's etymology traced back to the Wookiees' tumultuous history. Much as he'd tried to play nice in the time since, the cold shoulder and clipped answers continued. On Nar Shaddaa, Chewie would regularly disappear without even so much as a check-in. While planetside elsewhere, Han had expected on more than one occasion that he'd reenter the ship and find it empty. Chewie gone, not having said goodbye or even a 'Fuck you' to his face, just evaporating into the churning throng of sentients at whatever spaceport they were docked at. It's how the Wook had come into his life, more or less. Sort of fitting if he left that way, too.

Slowly, he climbed the ramp, his legs heavy as his hearing stretched out for signs of life. Though at first he sensed silence, he eventually heard an intermittent tapping. He speculated at first what of the ship might cause such a sound, light and random as it seemed, but he followed the noise into the lounge and then fell back on his heels as the massive, hairy form folded over the table registered. Still curious, Han peered around the Wook's shaggy arm that was propping up his big head to pick out the checkered pattern of a game board. Dejarik, Han answered himself…fitting that an engineer and puzzler would like dejarik. Another tap, then a second, as a game piece and its destination were selected.

[*Finished*?] the Wook asked dryly, attention still focused on his play.

"Uh, yeah, payment went through." He perused the interior, trying to spot if anything had changed in the last few hours.

[*Nothing to report*] Chewie answered.

Han cooled; was he that predictable? "Well, no news is good news. Everything square in the cargo bay?"

Only a nod answered him. Chewie continued the game, moving his pieces around the board in a strange silence. Dejarik required planning and strategy, but most boards still had some kind of humorous audio to accompany the pieces as they moved and

conquered in their advancement to the desired central square. Chewie must have turned the volume off.

Han caved under the grating stillness. "You about ready to head out?" he asked, hearing himself strain to sound genial and open ended instead of pushy.

Another game piece moved. [*Almost*] the Wook answered, again low and dull.

Han exhaled with big, puffy cheeks. "Okay, well, I'll go get started then," he mumbled to himself. He hesitated for a breath, curious if there might be a response–a grumble, a grunt, *something*–but only silence met him.

Half the pre-flight checks had already been completed–including some that belonged to the copilot–by the time Chewie pottered into the cockpit. Silently, he eased into his seat, voicelessly resuming his half of the work. Han watched him out of his periphery, partly to get the read on Chewie's mimed signals of various readouts and system tests, and partly to find his angle.

"Picked up a dejarik board?" he finally murmured, spoken enough like an aside so he could tell himself that perhaps the Wook hadn't heard him if he didn't answer.

[*Picked it off a scrap ship*.]

Surprised at the response–its existence, not its contents–Han paused just a beat in his task. "It's a good way to spend the time."

[*I ran out of other ways to keep myself occupied*.] The big chest expanded and collapsed in a heaving huff. [*It's tiring…being stuck on the ship*.]

At this, Han measurably slowed. Expanding their destinations–prowling deeper and deeper into Imperial space–had of course meant restrictions, sometimes quite severe, on Chewie's movement. They'd even had to hurriedly stuff him into an engine compartment to survive an impromptu customs check, something they had drilled for but just barely executed. Yet, Han perceived, the boredom of staying ship-bound wasn't really Chewie's gripe; he was

tired of the anxiety of spending days only a hairbreadth from discovery. Recapture.

Han sucked in a long breath, exhaled, nodded. "I'm workin' on it."

This made Chewie swivel his head around. [*What*?]

Another inhale first, which he let out long. "Uh, I don't wanna say just yet, in case it falls through. But if I'm right…you'll be the first to know."

The blue eyes hesitated for a beat, then fell away.

Disappointment, Han read. Lately, it seemed Chewie never looked at him with anything but. Yet he'd meant it, that he was working on it. To pull it off, though, he needed to ask a favor.

* * *

Nar Shaddaa's hazy gray skies gave way to a blue-tinted dusk as they cut through atmospheric smog and swooped over the Dicada Swamps bearing west towards Kha'art Hadash. The closer they advanced, the more the water gave way to development and then to density. He followed the familiar path in and around the Industrial Sector, banking and rolling gently, eventually arriving at the gaping hole between two silos that was the entrance to the access chute for Shug's Spacebarn. Inside the ship, the cockpit went black save for the periodic flash of light from the tunnel's safety lanterns. After only thirty or so seconds, the little red 'Suub glided into the sprawling hangar, and Han guided them to the familiar empty spot in the middle.

Mid post-flight routine, Han paused to check the local time. It was not late, per se–not that Nar Shaddaa had hard and fast ideas about schedules. Plenty on this moon would bustle far into the morning and recede only just before dawn; smugglers, like xandu, seemed to move most comfortably under the dark of night. It was *later*, though, and Han would prefer to ask his favor with as little disadvantage as possible; if he was going to say anything today, his

window was closing. He tried to, as he had the whole trip, predict how exactly to go about asking. How much to preface, feel out before he said anything, or whether he should just rip the bandage off in one go. A sour response–or none at all–would likely happen regardless however much he tried to break the ice. He opened his comm, reread the message he had scrawled a couple hours ago in between rounds of Solitary, then held his breath as he sent it off.

[*Do you want to just unload the cargo now or wait?*]

His eyes darted up to see Chewie staring at him, half-sitting in his seat in anticipation of Han's answer.

"Either or. Whatever you're up to."

[*Let's just get it over with*] the Wook exhaled as he got up to leave.

How I feel about a lot of things, Han mused to himself as he followed. Chewie had already made it to the hold by the time Han reached the top of the gangplank. If he was lucky, Han surmised, he could sidestep the little tramp and just leave him a message to scoop by and pick the cargo up later, when he wasn't around, so he'd not have to–

"Captain Solo! Whatcha got for me this time?"

Han's eyes rolled back into his head: he hadn't even finished dropping the ramp yet. Funny how the kid worked the Market, and yet *always* immediately manifested upon their return.

"I got flour, few different types," the Corellian answered tiredly as he descended.

"Packaged?" the kid queried.

Han winced. "*Of course*, packaged. What the hell would I do with four crates of unboxed flour?"

"Just checking," Jarik clarified, withdrawing slightly, before turning his focus to the contents of the hold that were lowering slowly. The kid walked over and waved up at the Wookiee gawking down at him from the ship's belly with a cheery, "Hi, Chewbacca!" In response, a friendly bark and growl returned the gesture.

Han huffed as his hands found his hips, and he shifted his

weight from one foot to the other. Irritation had worked its way down his legs. He noticed only then how much his fingers tingled, too, how shallowly he breathed. He checked his comm. No answer.

"Hey, can we pick up the pace?" he probed, suppressing another huff.

"Sorry, Captain Solo," Jarik obliged, "I'll be quick as can be." As though to prove it, the kid ran over to his forklift and climbed into the controls. In jerking motions, he brought the machine forward, nearly puncturing one of the crates.

"Careful!" Han shouted, holding a hand out like it might stop an accident.

Jarik blushed a deep red, shrinking down almost behind the yoke, and barely eked out an apology. From above, Chewie shouted out a few words of encouragement and direction in halting syntax so the kid could comprehend. With a second, slower attempt, the forklift secured the load and then pulled back. The crates cleared, the hold whined as it lifted back into position.

"No low ball offers," Han clarified once the machine stopped. "I bought some nice quality stuff. That alieri flour will make the best damn rolls you've ever had, so cap the price for that at about a hundred over the rest."

"Understood," the kid chirped, but sputtered out an, "Um, but–" follow up when Han briskly turned on his heel.

Han swiveled around. "*What*, Jarik? If you're gonna ask me again about gettin' on this damn ship, I swear to you, I'm gonna stop doin' business with you. No, you cannot come with. This is a two person operation and all positions are occupied."

The kid tried and failed to hide how crestfallen he felt. "But I could at least help with sales–"

Han gestured at the crates. "I don't *look* like I need help with picking up goods, do I?"

The scrunch of the kid's face suggested he had his doubts, but he merely frowned his disagreement and slinked away with the payload.

Once sure he was alone again, Han checked the comm. Still nothing. He huffed out his vexation, his disappointment, and stuffed the comm back into his pocket just as Chewie exited the ship, satchel in hand.

He paused in front of the keypad. [*Done in there*?]

Han stared at the ship for a beat, his mind working, then waved the question away. "For now. I'll get more clothes in the morning." He watched the Wook punch in the code to close the ship up. "You headed to the apartment?"

[*I'll take a walk first*] he answered. [*Stretch my legs*.]

"Yeah," Han breathed, noting the uncomfortable tension in his diaphragm. "Not a bad idea."

They took the elevator and the long walk through the adjacent mall together in silence, then only gave a nod of acknowledgement as they parted ways, Chewie heading in the opposite direction of their apartment while Han headed down. He considered for about half a staircase if he should walk down to grab dinner at The Blue Light, his thus-far favorite tavern, but sitting stationary, even to eat, didn't sound very appealing. His hands still twitched and his mind was buzzing. He needed to be fully occupied, all senses and thoughts at vigil. He needed the sims.

He exited the staircase at Level 10, cutting across a janky concourse to move perpendicular, closer to the larger port. He walked hurriedly, cognizant of appearing busy, letting his hand swing past his blaster lest anyone think about getting stupid. Finally, he entered a covered arcade and made for the third storefront on his right. The windows and doors all blacked out, the entrance gave in a smooth swoop and enveloped him in the too-bright white light of the lobby.

The droid at the desk recognized him, and the large spider-like arms swiveled in anticipation.

"Booth four open?" Han questioned as he handed over his card. Booth four, in his opinion, mirrored space conditions most accurately. The controls on many of the others lagged too much from overuse, and he'd found the bucket seat in booth one sticky one time

and refused to revisit, even after complaining and being reassured later it had been cleaned.

"Booth Four is occupied," the droid answered plainly, running Han's card to pull up his account. On it was stored all the data that would let the sim replicate sitting in his ship's cockpit, along with a number of courses he had purchased to practice everything from evasive maneuvers to in-air pickups and dropoffs to heavy atmospheric conditions. Certain spaceroutes, too, could be mimicked, and he'd already bought the one he intended to practice on a couple months ago.

Han chewed at his lip, peeping down the nearby aisle to assess which next option he preferred. In doing so, he caught the gaze of a Cosian staring hard at him as it hovered outside the fifth booth. Han's eyes glanced past the sentient, focusing instead on selecting his choice. By the time he'd turned back to the droid to ask about booth nine, the Cosian had disappeared into his sim.

Han leaned in as he passed over his payment for the service. "Who's in five?" he questioned with a hushed tone.

The droid, expressionless of course, turned its head as it computed. "A newcomer."

"New from where?"

"Recently arrived from Besadii service," the droid answered. "Running a simulation for D'Qar."

Han half-smirked, half-sneered. A newcomer switching sides to the Desilijic, he reasoned. The Cosian was sizing up the competition. Competition, indeed, he touted, as he made his way down to booth nine.

An open doorway met him, and inside, he stared into a blackness punctuated by runner lights. He eased in, the geometry of the space more than familiar, and slid himself into the bucket seat. His gloves, he realized as he took hold of the controls…he'd forgotten his gloves. Not a deal breaker, he resigned, then keyed for the rest of the program to begin. The seat lifted him up slightly into the air, and the wide screen before him came alive, a Head Up Display splashing

across the spotted black with the typical readouts of his ship. He reviewed them, noting that he needed to update the program after his recent replacement of one of the boosters in his sublight engine (one that meant more explosive power but slightly more weight). Otherwise, the readouts were spot on. Through a different menu, he perused the options, then stared at the words for a beat before he could select the course: the Kessel Run.

There were two primary reasons to thread through the Kessel Run. The first was to access Kessel, the singular location where glitterstim was mined. Glitterstim, however, was vertically managed through the Besadii. That had been Han's purpose when he'd done that six month stint with them between ditching Shrike and entering the Academy–flying consumer-ready glitterstim off of the refineries on Ylesia and rendezvousing with actual smugglers at a variety of transfer locations in the dead pockets of space. Now, working for the Desilijic, heading too close to Kessel would be a death wish in itself.

Its other function was as a useful shortcut, a convenient means of shaving time off a flight path or sidestepping undesired company on any of the conventional hyperspace lanes. Most smugglers knew *of* it, talked big in cantinas about making The Run someday, but few actually tried, and fewer came back. The risks were numerous. The threat wasn't pirates–though pirates of course also used and hid in pockets along the route. It was space itself. In The Run, you didn't get to go slow, change your mind, pull out. There was no drifting, no recalibrating, no second chances, no *stopping*. Stopping equaled–not risked, *equaled*–annihilation. You either came out the other side or you didn't.

Technically speaking, the Kessel Run consisted of two sections. In the Maw, a pilot faced relatively stationary foes–a series of black holes, a few neutron stars, and a handful of main sequence stars–though stationary hardly meant 'easier.' Threading through warped space, where the obstacles sometimes sat invisible until it was too late, meant navigational errors weren't forgiven. Once swallowed by an event horizon, no amount of correcting would change the

outcome. The Pit, however, offered no better luck. Dodging asteroids that were all in a tumultuous tumble, ricocheting off one another in vectors that fluctuated too fast for even the computers to keep up, was a challenge that tested a pilot's reaction time and predictive skill. One slip at the wrong time and a ship would dissipate into a shower of indeterminate pieces, a light show for no one.

Han studied the screen, debating which version he wanted to attempt. He'd run this simulation probably thirty times so far and had yet to decide which half of The Run he found more difficult–the Pit or the Maw. The Maw at least had a couple more conservative pathways through it, depending on how the starfield had spun and twisted around itself. A pilot would still have to go barreling through it, but as long as some of the more pernicious beasts were accounted for, it was possible to chart a course that didn't risk as much. Of course, Han never took those options, and preferred to shave it as close as reasonable to each behemoth's edge, shaving off not just time but distance in its completion.

But the Pit…the bulk of the times he'd crashed out in his simulations had been in the asteroid field. There were so many vectors to keep track of. He told himself it was because the ship's computer didn't properly imitate an actual copilot, whose job would be to read the radar and call out incoming objects so the pilot could focus on the field ahead and make adjustments accordingly. The bot always called objects much too late, often because it was busy reading objects that were too far to matter. Or maybe, just maybe, a small voice in him prodded, it was him. That he wasn't ready yet.

He frowned. Selected the Pit. Start there. Survive. And then have the endurance to not get eaten by the Maw.

The simulation began, as always, with the strange kickback of his seat suspensions that marked the passive programs beginning to mimic the environment of the Pit. The sensation had thrown him the first couple times–the Navy sims had never done that–but he'd come to appreciate the jolt, a welcome reminder to his nervous system to fully come online. He sat straighter, even slightly forward, his left

hand at the ready on the yoke while his right gripped tight the more refined controls for his complementary thrusters. He winced at the field in front of him, the dead space of the Black prior to formally entering The Run, though as yet he could make out no detail. He'd have to get closer. He engaged thrusters, steady, unyielding.

As he neared, the Pit opened before him: kilometer-wide nickel-iron lumps in slow roll, ice boulders hissing their own fog, ribbons of refinery slag and dust plumes charged enough to arc when they kissed. Occasionally, crumpled pieces of old ship-skin floated past. Right now the flow bent left, a fat iron mass pinwheeling and shepherding a stream of smaller rocklets. Moving the ship forward, he crossed under its limb at a shallow oblique, notching a burst of throttle through the nearest clear negative space, already banking for the hole two moves ahead.

Favor technique over map—that was the Run's first lesson. Responsiveness over pride was the second. He let the ship "float tight," hands soft on the stick, throttle nudged rather than punched. Somewhere in there a memory slid in at an angle: sitting at Rho's right, eyes glued to the screens to call out and somehow also watching the Old Man, noticing how oddly light he managed to keep his hands no matter how violent the field decided to be. Rho hadn't been fast in the way bar stories loved–he'd been exact. Han had wanted to be exact, too…just *faster*.

The first third was all breath and grind. He kept the yoke in small, quick movements and let the 'Suub-sim slip and slide rather than jerk. She complained: micro-rattle in the panel, warnings of overheating in his port controls, a judder of his seat as he made the ship take the microhit of space dust and debris instead of risking twisting around a larger rock. He rode it anyway, pulsing thrust to hop a slurry of ice shards, knifing the nose up to let a fist of rock sail clean through his nadir. An impact klaxon chirped and he killed it with a thumb without looking. The ship could take being hurried; she hated being manhandled. He pushed her, but he didn't shove.

Sometimes, though, he did need to get fancy. That's when

muscle memory kicked in, the swoop instincts that had learned to read a track by the way the yoke hummed, the way air bent around a turn. The track had taught him how to trust momentum. He leaned the ship into the field the way he'd once leaned a swoop into a bend—eyes forward, peripheral wide, breath steady. The sim flashed collision vectors faster than a sane person could parse. He didn't bother to parse, instead found the rhythm, used it to cut under a big spinner turning lazily on its side, then used its wake to slingshot through the gap that would open just in time between it and a neighbor. When the bot chirped in alarm, he ignored it. The bot didn't know the rhythm.

Finally, he reached the middle of the Pit–the treacherous lull, the exhale inside the storm. Here, the clutter thinned, the field seeming—deceptively—like open road. This was where novices died and pirates were most likely. He couldn't let the yoke relax. He kept the ship alive and brisk, kept a bias on the starboard vane to guard against a blindside, and only then stole a second to peel one damp palm off the grip and drag it down his pant leg. The yoke felt slick anyway and the slip set his teeth on edge. *Breathe*, he reminded himself; this was the moment to suck in a deep breath despite the vice on the lungs. But don't stop or slow down or do anything except keep moving forward.

The second half hit fast and technical. Tumblers pivoted in coupled pairs, and he used their wakes like riptides, slingshotting off one to fall into the lee of another, throttle feathers so short they were more intention than motion. He pitched up to clear a jag of spinning ore, rolled through into a descending double curve, and caught a timing seam you could miss just by blinking. The sim's inertial model was honest—every burst left him a hair out of square. He could feel the line now, the thin thread you ride when you're right on the cusp of over-flying your ship and making her sing anyway.

Suddenly, a chime. Tiny, crystalline, nothing like the sim's call. It threaded his ear and didn't belong, and his brain misfiled it—proximity? overtemp?—before recognizing the timbre wasn't ship at all. Comm, he realized distantly.

Comm. Rho.

The half-thought cost him his lead on the next seam. The big iron ahead rolled just a touch faster than his last check, and his burst came a beat too late. The portside collision hit like a swung anvil. The ‘Suub snapped into a spin, stars and stone swirling into a pinwheel. He tried to kick on his starboard thrusters to stabilize, yanked power to break the tumble, and a second chunk—smaller, meaner—caught the belly and sent him slewing down the face of a planetoid. The viewscreen blurred, the HUD flashed red, and the sim cut to black with a neat, clinical tone.

He sat limp and dumb in his seat as it lowered. Flashes of the last few seconds of his flight blinded his inner eye, and he scrutinized them–where had that second hit come from?! How had he missed it?! Part flabbergasted, part pissed, he booted up the readouts from his attempt, wound it back just enough to try and catch the error, identify it: his or the damn bot? His attention fluttered over the radar map, comparing it against the documented read out from the bot. No, the bot had said nothing about anything coming up from below. Maybe it would have, if he’d not spinned out…maybe the rock would have missed him. But that was a bad judgement call he hoped no real copilot of his would ever make.

He exhaled long, stretching through his shoulders, gently twisting through his back and flexing his toes. How tense his quads were, he recognized with surprise, his hands massaging down his legs. He took in and let go of another big breath, letting himself come down slowly from the cocktail of adrenal hormones surging through him. His pulse began to slow, he retrieved his comm and first checked the time. An hour…how quickly the time went by. How exhausted he felt, and he’d only done about a third of the entire Run. He added a task to his mental to-do list–some time in the gym, particularly cardio–then switched into his communications log.

He’d not imagined it, as some part of him wondered if he had. A message from Rho waited to be opened. He stared at it long, anxious and hesitant. For a beat, he questioned not reading it, putting

it off until maybe he'd rested. At least had taken a shower. And then some other part of him knew he'd know no rest. Impulse had made him send the message; impulse needed to make him read it.

You around? he'd asked.

The answer: *Fathier's Haunches. A jog from Veno's. Bring Chewie*.

Han panted. An answer…like nothing had happened. Like nothing had changed.

He readjusted himself in his seat, noticed how unburdened his shoulders suddenly felt, and sat a little straighter. "Okay. Alright," he breathed to himself in the half-lit room. He'd go. He recognized the tavern Rho mentioned–it was slightly more than a 'jog,' but not that much farther. He could just head over. And then he assessed himself, registered just how much his clothes stuck to him in damp sweat. A shower, some fresh clothes would not be a bad idea. Their new apartment–leased shortly after securing the first payment under his new percentage cut–had an excellent shower, he'd made sure of that, and was only a few levels above. But Chewie might have returned already.

Han chewed his lip, deliberating. The sonic shower on the ship was mediocre, but worked, and to backtrack to Shug's wouldn't put him that far away. The extra distance was worth sparing himself the Wook's dour company. His mind made up, he shot off another message saying he'd be there shortly.

Rushing back to the ship had made him break out into sweat again, and hurriedly, he flung his clothes off him and jumped into the shower stall. Though rushing, this entire process was so routine that his mind couldn't help but drift. Spin, in an effort to prepare. Why?–Rho was going to ask him why, same as he did when he'd begged the Old Man to take him through The Run back when Han was still training with him. At the time, Han had chalked it up to curiosity. He'd wanted to see it for himself…see if it really was as tumultuous, as testy, as people said.

Now? Well, why did any of them want to do it? Practically

speaking, it was handy, helpful in a bind to have a backdoor of sorts one could slip out of, to resist seizure for another day.

But the truth? The truth for all of them was the prestige. The proof of skill–of excellence, really. For The Run to personally remain as yet unconquered nagged at him. He could do a lot in the captain's chair–he'd *done* a lot–but knowing that there was this thing that he had not done, not on his own and not with his ship…it ate at him to have to wonder if perhaps he *couldn't*.

Fathier's Haunches smelled like smoked fat and frying herbs from as far away as a block down, the kind of savory that clung to clothes and settled into hair. The smell intensified as the door opened, and with the wall of aroma came the low roar of a busy tavern. Crowded, he judged right away, then paused once inside, letting his eyes adjust for a second, pulse still a click too high from the walk over. As everything came into focus, he took stock of the tavern. A mural of a charging fathier ran the length of the back wall—hips and shoulders exaggerated, all speed and muscle—while twin strings of cracked amber bulbs draped low over the room, casting everything in a warm dusk. Somewhere around a corner, music played–live, he guessed, judging by the crowd, who seemed to occasionally throw their attention somewhere besides their barmates.

Movement behind him at the threshold pushed him forward. His head swung around, scanning the bartop for the unmistakable roundness of Rho, and then his gaze picked through the guests at the nearby bartops. He couldn't help a frown to realize he'd need to head deeper into the restaurant. Slowly, he threaded through the bodies and tabletops, giving wide berth to elbows and conversation.

It wasn't until he entered the central aisle that he realized with dismay his assumption. Near the back, two tables had been dragged together, their tops laden with plates and half-empties while encircled around them sat seven individuals all leaning in like buddies. At the head, right near the back, sat Rho, his shoulders loose and an amused

smile on his face as he listened to something his nearest neighbor said. How stupid of him, Han chastised as he stalled mid-stride: of course Rho wasn't alone.

Apprehension sunk in. Maybe this was a bad idea…or at least bad timing. If he pivoted now, he could be out the door in three steps and blame it later on a misread time. He could message: *Got caught up. Rain check?* That might be stupid, risking pissing Rho off any more than he might already be, especially when Han needed his help, but the alternative felt stupider.

He didn't choose fast enough. Maybe it was his pivot to leave that caught the Old Man's attention, but across the din, Rho's gaze fixed. His eyes flashed with recognition, then an easy light—no surprise, no flinch. He lifted his chin in invitation, then at Han's hesitation, emphatically waved him over. Han's feet found forward again before any part of him could protest, though an unease rippled through his middle.

As he closed the distance, and others at the table flitted eyes over the newcomer, the air around the table seemed to constrict. The conversation noticeably thinned, some of them exchanging silent glances with each other, recognizing, assessing, calculating. One of them, a sizable Togruta, seemed to mumble something to the group and left. Han didn't catch the words, but he caught the look: disgust. He kept his face blank, his movements wooden, under their scrutiny, his eyes locked ahead of him on Rho.

The Old Man had taken a swig of some goblet and then lowered it at Han's approach. He frowned. "No Chewie?"

Han sputtered, a hot flush at his ears. "Oh. Uh, no. No Chewie."

"That's too bad," Rho waxed, turning back to his cohort. "Can't understand a lick of what the guy says, but he's a good fellow."

The table nodded at Rho's comment, though none of them piped in. Instead, they busied themselves, refilling their glasses from pitchers or checking comm messages, occasionally stealing another glance at Han then at Rho before resuming whatever distraction they

could find. Han furtively investigated them, too. Though he'd been sure he'd seen no familiar faces, another quick sweep revealed he *did* recognize some of these people: the light skinned human on Rho's left ran an export business specializing in produce, and the Twi'lek at his right imported from the spinwise edges of the Outer Rim.

"Here," Rho continued, gesturing beyond Han's hip at a nearby empty table, "grab a chair. Join us!"

At the invite, Han's peripheral picked up the uncomfortable shuffle of the table.

"Actually, I–" Flustered, Han forced a smirk, recalibrated. "I was hoping to talk."

Rho shrugged at him, open faced, either polite or not understanding. "We can talk here."

Again, Han made a covert glance at the other company, curious whether they had still disengaged or whether they were staring on now, either daring Han to try or aghast at Rho for insisting. He found no blatant resistance, but still leaned forward to the Old Man. "Something I'd like to say one-on-one," he said, quiet enough to suggest privacy and yet still audible to the silent table.

Rho didn't hesitate. "Well, then, help me to the bar so I can top everybody off." Swaggering, he swiveled his head around to his comrades and gave a jaunty laugh. "Mine turn, ain't it?"

A few hands came up in polite disagreement, and the Twi'lek clarified: "No, Big Man–you're caught up." Her gaze iced as it turned to Han. "Take care of the kid."

For a beat, it seemed as though Rho might argue, but he conceded. "If you say so. Whoever's got next round–no more liquor for me. Throw me anything they have on tap that's dark, but no bubbles–it gives me gas." Waving the table off, he strained as he rose to his feet. Creakily, he took his first few steps. "These knees and these hips don't work like they used to. This thing don't help, either," he added with a laugh, patting himself on his overextended gut. Finally finding his stride, he turned to Han with a grin. "Piece of advice: don't get old."

Han reflexively smiled, the idea of himself as old only fluttering through his consciousness. "Well, you ain't there, yet."

"Fast approaching," Rho ribbed, red-faced with merriment, "but what else can I do but enjoy the ride?"

They drifted toward the bar together, the path through the crowd easier with Rho absorbing glances, like always. At the bartop, the Old Man was quick to take a seat again, waved a friendly hello to the bartender and then gestured at Han with raised brows. Han declined.

Rho settled himself in his seat with a grunt. "Well, it's good to hear from you. Seems I don't see much of you these days."

Han hesitated a beat. He came here aware he might have to submit to this conversation. Maybe even withstand interrogation. Certainly scrutiny. Maybe he'd fooled himself into thinking it wouldn't come quite so fast.

"Working," Han answered plainly. "Been real busy."

Rho nodded slowly. "Yeah. Been seein' that. Shug says you've become a mighty fine client."

Han flushed and laughed to cover it. "Yeah," he admitted, fighting a smile. "Ship's been better. A lot better. Actually, that's kinda what I wanted to talk to you about." He paused, a bit unsure how to phrase it, and in the silence, Rho steadied and met his gaze, intently listening. The attention caused the younger man to drop his chin and fiddle the seam on the leather chair at his elbow. "Listen, I was wondering…" Han licked the corner of his lips, then squared his jaw. "Come with me on a Kessel Run."

At mention of the route, whatever inebriation Rho had thus far enjoyed evaporated. His eyes ever so slightly narrowed. The rest of him, however, remained still, giving at least the semblance of poise. "D'you really think that's smart?"

Han sucked in a big breath before answering. "I've been on the sims. I've been running it, Rho–I have. I think I've got it."

"You know as well as I do the limitations of those things," Rho reproved. "I told you before, they're a good place to start, but if they

matched what can happen up there, nobody'd need me. Nobody'd need *anybody* to teach 'em."

"I know," Han cajoled. "That's why I need you to come with. I know we ran it–what, over a year ago? But…listen, I know I can be cocky. I'm *good*, and I know it. But I ain't stupid. I know my limits; I know when I'm in over my head. I go barreling into the Kessel Run by my lonesome, and it'll be a death sentence. I ain't looking to go out like that."

Rho considered for a moment, then tightly shook his head. "It ain't you I'm worried about, Solo."

Han pulled in. "She can do it. I've been building her up, pushing her. She can do it."

"I'll bet." The Old Man did a poor job veiling his skepticism, then rhythmically knocked his fist on the bar in thought. "You've had her up in the Runs or you just messin' with the computers?" he finally asked.

Han nodded a bit too eagerly. "Yeah, I've taken her up there, too."

"You makin' time?" An unabashedly skeptical probe.

Han tossed his head around. "No," he answered flatly, then rebounded, "but I've been up there by myself. Haven't brought Chewie yet."

Rho exhaled sharply, a touch sarcastic. "That's its own issue." His eyes danced around at nothing in the distance, deliberating, and the vacillation in his response made Han break out into a mild sweat. Finally, Rho turned back to him with a sigh of resignation. "You're gonna show me."

Han panted out the tension in his chest. "In the Runs?"

"In the Runs. Show me what she can do up there, and then we'll talk about it." He sagged slightly in his seat. "I'm busy the next couple days–I already promised Jan I'd go up with his cousin or something, and then I'm taking Lwyll out to dinner the day after. But day after next–early–we can go."

Han gulped, then gave a tight smile. "Great. Thanks. Really

appreciate it."

Rho smiled, though it took effort, and his disposition easing back into something more relaxed. "Well, that's what I do," he waxed. "Now, c'mon, tell me what you want to drink, I'll take care of you. That table could use some young blood at it."

Han shook his head. "Nah, Rho, I…uh–I'm gonna call it a night." He half-smirked. "Got back only a little while ago. Long day."

The Old Man considered for a moment, then his bottom lip pouted. "Okay. I'll see you later, then."

They walked back together as far as the main corridor of the restaurant, then shook their goodbyes. Han was quick to dip out, and once on the street in the warm air of the evening, the totality of the exchange replayed for him. Truly, the more he walked, the more it sunk it what would happen: he'd do the run; Rho would be so impressed, the Old Man would recommend a change in Han's status to the Hutts; Han would get to take the 'Suub–his ship, the one everybody had talked shit about for so long–on a Kessel Run, and shut all of them up. A big smile crawled up his face as he imagined it, the way everyone would look at him then. They way they'd talk about him.

Stopping at an intersection, he planned his next move. He wasn't going to bed–there was no way, he was too…giddy. He wanted to celebrate, he decided. Do something *fun*. He ran through options, declining dinner and pick-up wallball and betting on shockboxing at the bar. Then his thoughts switched to the apartment a slew of levels up that housed good company. Or, at least, it would if his math was correct and she was home. Starting toward a grocer he really liked, Han pulled his comm from his jacket pocket and double checked her location. Yup, as he suspected, she was in. He considered for a moment if he should ping her, give her a heads up, and then just as swiftly decided against it. She never turned him away when he showed up at her door.

About half an hour later, swinging a bag of groceries at his

knees, he buzzed at her apartment. Habitually, he checked behind him at the alleyway while he waited, then at the click of her building comm, leaned in anticipatorily.

"I distinctly remember telling you to ask me if you could come over," came her growl over the comm. Even with the distortion, he could hear the darkness in her voice. He liked it.

"Oh," he feigned, "yeah. Well, I was in the area, so…I figured I might as well stop by."

A pause. "I don't feel too great."

Han smiled. She'd tried this before. Not that it wasn't true, but for her to think it'd shake him off… "Well, then, you'll have to let me in there. I can make you something to feel better."

He was met with silence. He wondered for a moment if she might actually turn him away, and he started planning his excuse to leave instead. Then, she grunted, as though about to start to talk, but instead let go of a long sigh. The comm signal ended. Her door buzzed open.

She'd left the door of her apartment ajar for him, and he stepped in to close and lock it behind him. He took a quick sweep of the interior, at least what he could see from the entrance, but didn't spot her, and crossed into the kitchen to unload the groceries. He picked through his bag and inspected again his ingredients: already diced shaak, forgivably pre-seasoned to protect Salla's sensitive stomach; a package of flatbread; an already prepped cold salad of charred red peppers; and a container of nerf yogurt that he would quickly doctor into a tangy sauce. For that purpose, he'd also grabbed a vine of ponzu and a knob of kybuck bulb, but then, staring at it, doubted if he should put the kybuck in the yogurt if he had any hopes or intention of putting his tongue down Salla's throat later.

"I didn't realize you were planetside."

Han pivoted to see Salla leaning against the opening to the living room, her arms crossed over a pajama set of dark copper that matched her skin. Her hair was up, tied back into her nightcap, and it was evident she'd already washed her face. Her amber eyes

narrowed in pre-disapproval of his answer, her full lips somehow pulled thin.

He half-grinned. "Just got in. Had to talk to Rho about something first." Estimating her again, fully aware of what the answer was, he gestured at the countertop covered in food. "You hungry?"

"No," she said flatly. "I told you, I don't feel well. I was going to go to bed early."

"Oh." He withdrew slightly. Perhaps this *wasn't* a great idea: he *was* hungry. "Well, I could hang out for a little bit, yeah? Until you're ready for bed?"

She stared at him long first, then uncrossed her arms and disappeared into the living room.

Han stifled a grunt at her leaving, then opened her cooler, stuffing the items in. If he played this right, he could stay the night, and just cook all this off after she fell asleep. Then he could put as much kybuck in the yogurt as he damn well pleased.

He removed his boots near the door, as he should have done right when walking in, then stepped into the living room. Not finding her there, he peeked into her bedroom, and found her putting some clothes away. Beyond her, in a chair in the corner, she had sat a bag, half-full, the opening still undone like she was packing.

He gestured at the bag. "You on your way out?"

"Not for a few days. Rendezvous around Arat Fraca for a BlasTech order, and then around the Colonies." She eyed the blaster at his thigh. "I could set one aside for you–a 15-S? Replace that damaged thing."

"It's not *damaged*," he told her again, a smidge irritated at her recurring tease. "I like it like that."

She ignored his answer and his tone, silently moving through her chores.

He watched her for a beat, chewing first on his next words. "How long you'll be gone?"

"Three weeks," she answered as she tucked her clothes into

her dresser.

His brows raised–that was longer than usual. He wondered quickly *why* she'd be gone so long, but brushed the question away and chose charm instead. "Well then, good thing I stopped by."

She smoothly closed the dresser drawer. "Han, if you came here for that, you wasted a trip," she told him, her eyes flat. "I had an early morning, I'm tired, and my stomach and head hurt."

He shifted his weight on his feet first and found a smile to wear. "Hey, yeah…of course not. Look, you know we don't have to have sex each time I come over, right?"

She retreated slightly, not physically but in her eyes. He could almost see her calculus spelled out above her: in roughly the year they'd been seeing each other, they'd never *not* fooled around to at least some degree. No matter what else happened in their time together, *that* happened. If it wasn't a requirement, then, a precondition…what was this?

She eyed him then, strung somewhere between apprehension and doubt. "So, if we just watch a holofilm until we fall asleep…you won't be mad?"

He gave an exaggerated shrug. "Mad? I won't be mad–you don't feel well." He walked past her and crossed around the bed, then began to remove his holster. "I could use some good rest."

She remained in place and watched him strip off the rest of his outside clothes. Only when he crawled into bed and stared at her did she move from her spot, cautiously walking forward to join him.

"Do you care what film it is?" he continued, forcing his tone bright. "I haven't watched *The Kallea Cycle* in a while. Monologues will be good to fall asleep to."

She weakly smiled, like there was hesitation in doing so, then slowly shook her head and handed him the controller. While she settled in beside him, he fiddled through her console, finding the film and starting it. The room lights automatically dimmed as low as they could go, and the projector screen across from her bed went black…sort of. Nothing, really, could mimic how dark real space was.

He shimmied down into the bed, pulling up the covers slightly to drape across his chest, and then felt Salla nudge at his shoulder. She was curling into him he realized, only slightly laying her head at his shoulder, and he stifled another grunt, turning his attention back to the screen.

As the opening credits played, his mouth contorted in a manner he hoped she did not see. He should have just gone out to dinner.